We had another good competition the following season and made the play-offs again. I got my first and only Twenty20 hundred against the Kochi Tuskers team. In fact, in those two seasons, I was consistent at the top of the order and there was talk about me playing for the Indian team for the World Twenty20 in the Caribbean in April–May 2010. However, the thought never crossed my mind. By early 2010 the Indian Twenty20 team had a settled look to it and it would not have been right to reconsider my decision not to play international Twenty20 cricket for just one tournament.

I thoroughly enjoyed my experiences in Twenty20 with the Mumbai Indians. The overwhelming sense of positivity that surrounds the team made playing for them a real pleasure. I also enjoyed being captain in the first four seasons, but I am glad that I then handed over the captaincy to Harbhajan, a decision that caused a stir in the media at the time. The fact was that 2011–12 was one of my toughest years in cricket and by the time of the fifth season of the IPL, which started on 4 April 2012, I was feeling mentally drained. I was in no position to cope with the stress of captaincy and just wanted to continue as a batsman. It was for this reason that I asked the owners to consider giving the captaincy to Harbhajan. I would be there to help and offer advice to him on and off the field, especially because he and I had always shared a great camaraderie while playing for India.

I have known Bhajji since 1994, when he first bowled a few doosras to me during practice in Chandigarh, and we became very good friends when he broke into the Indian team against Australia in Bangalore in 1998. Bhajji had already shown his mettle as captain of the Mumbai Indians in the Champions League Twenty20 in October 2011, which I missed through injury, when he did brilliantly to lead the team to the title.

The final season

I knew that 2013 was always going to be my last year in the IPL. Dedicating three more years to the IPL as a player after I turned 40 in April 2013 was never an option. I was desperate to win the title, having come so close in 2010. We had a good unit and all the players were fit going into the tournament. Ricky Ponting was now captain, John Wright